

SARI BUO

1

INTRODUCTION

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CHALLENGES

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SOLUTION

1

SARIBUO IS A MOVEMENT OF INDIVIDUALS — NOT JUST STUDENTS — UNITED TO RAISE AWARENESS ABOUT GENDER INEQUALITY IN THE PHILIPPINES.

SARIBUO IS A ONE-MAN TEAM ORGANIZATION THAT AIMS TO CONTRIBUTE TO THE FIGHT AGAINST GENDER INEQUALITY AND DISCRIMINATION IN OUR SOCIETY — THROUGH VIDEO GAME, NEWS FLASHCARDS, AND OTHER CREATIVE TOOLS THAT RAISE AWARENESS AND EDUCATE AUDIENCES.

WHAT STARTED AS A UNIVERSITY PROJECT BECAME A PURPOSE. SARIBUO IS THE CREATION OF AN INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY STUDENT DETERMINED TO USE TECHNOLOGY FOR GOOD — BUILDING RESOURCES THAT SPEAK UP AGAINST GENDER INEQUALITY IN THE PHILIPPINES.

FUELED BY THE STORIES OF FRIENDS AND STRANGERS ALIKE, I BUILT SARIBUO TO CHALLENGE THE DOMINANCE OF ONE GENDER OR MINDSET OVER OTHERS — AND TO STAND AGAINST THE DISCRIMINATION FACED BY THOSE WITH DIVERSE IDENTITIES AND SEXUALITIES.

FROM A ONE-MAN TEAM TO, HOPEFULLY, AN ORGANIZATION SUPPORTED BY MANY — SARIBUO IS ONE OF THE WAYS I CHOOSE TO CONTRIBUTE TO THE ONGOING FIGHT AGAINST GENDER INEQUALITY. SOME MAY CLAIM DISCRIMINATION ISN'T REAL, YET THEY CONTINUE TO MOCK OTHERS FOR THEIR GENDER IDENTITY OR WHO THEY ARE ATTRACTED TO. THAT CONTRADICTION IS EXACTLY WHY THIS PROJECT EXISTS.

SARIBUO ISN'T JUST A GAME OR A SCHOOL PROJECT I CREATED FOR GRADES — IT'S A CONTINUING PROJECT FOR A CONTINUING FIGHT AGAINST GENDER INEQUALITY.

JUSTIN FERNANDO

**DEVCON MANILA CONTENT MARKETING AND
AWS LEGARDA VICE CHIEF RELATIONS OFFICER
(EFFECTIVE JULY 21, 2025)**

2

OVERALL STATUS:

THE PHILIPPINES CLIMBED FIVE PLACES TO RANK 20TH GLOBALLY OUT OF 148 COUNTRIES IN THE **WORLD ECONOMIC FORUM'S (WEF)** GLOBAL GENDER GAP REPORT FOR 2025, WITH AN OVERALL GENDER PARITY SCORE OF 78.1%. IT REMAINS THE HIGHEST-RANKING SOUTHEAST ASIAN COUNTRY AND THIRD IN EAST ASIA AND THE PACIFIC (BEHIND NEW ZEALAND AND AUSTRALIA).

ONE SUCH AREA IS EDUCATION, WHERE THE COUNTRY SAW A RARE SLIP. FOR THE FIRST TIME, BOYS OUTNUMBERED GIRLS IN NET ENROLLMENT IN PRIMARY SCHOOL. THAT SHIFT CONTRIBUTED TO A 1.2 PERCENTAGE POINT DROP IN THE COUNTRY'S SCORE FOR EDUCATIONAL ATTAINMENT, WHICH HAD PREVIOUSLY HELD STEADY AT FULL PARITY.

POLITICAL EMPOWERMENT PRESENTS A MORE COMPLEX PICTURE. THE PHILIPPINES MAINTAINS A RELATIVELY HIGH SCORE IN THE HEAD-OF-STATE INDICATOR, LARGELY DUE TO THE LEGACIES OF FORMER PRESIDENTS **CORAZON AQUINO** AND **GLORIA MACAPAGAL-ARROYO**. THAT SCORE NOW STANDS AT 46.2 PERCENT, SECOND ONLY TO ONE OTHER COUNTRY IN THE REGION. BUT BROADER REPRESENTATION REMAINS UNEVEN. **WOMEN** HOLD JUST **38.9 PERCENT** OF SEATS IN PARLIAMENT, AND THEIR SHARE OF MINISTERIAL ROLES HAS DROPPED TO 21.1 PERCENT, DOWN FROM MORE THAN 30 PERCENT IN BOTH 2006 AND 2023

GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE (GBV)

REMAINS A PERVASIVE SOCIAL PROBLEM. ACCORDING TO THE 2022 NATIONAL DEMOGRAPHIC AND HEALTH SURVEY (NDHS) BY PSA, **17.5% OF FILIPINO WOMEN AGED 15-49 EXPERIENCED PHYSICAL, SEXUAL, OR EMOTIONAL VIOLENCE FROM INTIMATE PARTNERS.** IN 2023, THE PNP RECORDED **13,122 CASES OF VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN** (INCLUDING RAPE, HARASSMENT, SAFE SPACES ACT VIOLATIONS). ONLY 1 IN 3 WOMEN WHO EXPERIENCED VIOLENCE SOUGHT SUPPORT OR REPORTED IT.

A UN STUDY FOUND THAT **30% OF RESPONDENTS** IN THE PHILIPPINES REPORTED **BEING HARASSED, BULLIED, OR DISCRIMINATED** AGAINST AT WORK **DUE TO THEIR SOGIESC.**

DEEP-ROOTED SOCIETAL BIASES

A 2023 UNDP STUDY FOUND THAT **99.5% OF FILIPINOS** (BOTH MEN AND WOMEN) **HOLD SOME FORM OF BIAS AGAINST WOMEN,** INDICATING DEEPLY EMBEDDED SOCIETAL NORMS.

POLITICAL UNDERREPRESENTATION (BEYOND HEAD OF STATE)

DESPITE HIGH SCORES IN THE HEAD-OF-STATE INDICATOR, **FEMALE REPRESENTATION IN PARLIAMENT (38.9%)** AND MINISTERIAL ROLES (**21.1% IN 2025**) REMAINS A CHALLENGE.

ECONOMIC DISPARITIES & LEADERSHIP GAPS

WHILE ECONOMIC PARTICIPATION IS HIGH, **WOMEN'S LABOR FORCE PARTICIPATION (51.2%)** IS SIGNIFICANTLY **LOWER THAN MEN'S (75.4%) AS OF 2024.** FEWER WOMEN HOLD LEADERSHIP POSITIONS IN THE WORKFORCE.

DISCRIMINATION AND LACK OF LEGAL PROTECTION FOR LGBTQIA+ INDIVIDUALS

MENTAL HEALTH CRISIS

A 2024 PHILIPPINES NATIONAL SURVEY ON THE MENTAL HEALTH OF LGBTQ+ YOUNG PEOPLE (**THE TREVOR PROJECT**) REVEALED ALARMING STATISTICS: **75% HAVE SERIOUSLY CONSIDERED SUICIDE, 46% HAVE ATTEMPTED SUICIDE (34% IN THE PAST YEAR). 62% REPORTED RECENT SYMPTOMS OF DEPRESSION AND ANXIETY, AND 59% ENGAGED IN SELF-HARM. 19% REPORTED BEING THREATENED WITH OR SUBJECTED TO CONVERSION THERAPY.** THESE ARE LINKED TO **"MINORITY STRESS"** AND **SOCIAL EXCLUSION.**

LEGAL GAPS, SOGIESC EQUALITY BILL STALLED

THE SEXUAL ORIENTATION, GENDER IDENTITY OR EXPRESSION, AND SEX CHARACTERISTICS (SOGIESC) EQUALITY BILL HAS BEEN STALLED IN CONGRESS FOR **25 YEARS** DESPITE WIDESPREAD ADVOCACY AND GROWING PUBLIC SUPPORT.

VIOLENCE

THE COMMISSION ON HUMAN RIGHTS (CHR) CONDEMNED RECENT **KILLINGS OF TRANSGENDER WOMEN** IN JUNE 2025. LGBTQIA+ CHILDREN AND YOUTH ALSO **FACE** HEIGHTENED LEVELS OF DISCRIMINATION, BULLYING, AND EXCLUSION IN SCHOOLS.

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STRENGTHENING LEGAL FRAMEWORKS & POLICY IMPLEMENTATION

THE MAGNA CARTA OF WOMEN (RA 9710) REMAINS A CORNERSTONE. THE PHILIPPINE PLAN FOR GENDER-RESPONSIVE DEVELOPMENT (PPGD) 1995-2025 AND THE GENDER EQUALITY AND WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT (GEWE) PLAN 2019-2025 GUIDE GOVERNMENT EFFORTS. THE SAFE SPACES ACT (RA 11313) ADDRESSES GENDER-BASED SEXUAL HARASSMENT IN PUBLIC SPACES, WORKPLACES, AND ONLINE, BENEFITING ALL GENDERS AND SOGIESC.

GOVERNMENT AGENCIES ARE MANDATED TO FORMULATE GENDER AND DEVELOPMENT (GAD) PLANS AND BUDGETS. THE PHILIPPINE COMMISSION ON WOMEN (PCW) ISSUES GUIDELINES (E.G., PCW MEMORANDUM CIRCULAR NO. 2025-05 ON ESTABLISHING GAD CORNERS).

POLICIES LIKE RA 10023 AND RA 11573 (SIMPLIFYING LAND TITLING) HAVE SHOWN PROGRESS IN WOMEN'S PROPERTY RIGHTS, WITH WOMEN'S SHARE OF FREE PATENTS INCREASING.

ADDRESSING GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE

THE BIODIVERSITY MANAGEMENT BUREAU (BMB) KICKS OFF AN 18-DAY CAMPAIGN TO END VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN (NOVEMBER 25 - DECEMBER 12, 2024). THE PCW CONTINUES TO WORK WITH PARTNERS TO STRENGTHEN PREVENTION AND RESPONSE MECHANISMS. THESE EFFORTS SHOULD BE EXPANDED TO SPECIFICALLY ADDRESS VIOLENCE AGAINST LGBTQIA+ INDIVIDUALS.

VARIOUS GOVERNMENT AGENCIES (PNP, DSWD, PCW) AND NGOS PROVIDE HOTLINES, SHELTERS, AND SUPPORT SERVICES FOR VAW SURVIVORS. EFFORTS AIM TO IMPROVE REPORTING AND ACCESS TO JUSTICE, THOUGH UNDERREPORTING REMAINS A CHALLENGE.

PROMOTING WOMEN'S ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT

INITIATIVES FOCUS ON INCREASING WOMEN'S ACCESS TO DECENT WORK, SUPPORTING FEMALE ENTREPRENEURS, AND ADVOCATING FOR EQUITABLE PAY. THE 2025 ECC (**EMPLOYEE'S COMPENSATION COMMISSION**) NATIONAL WOMEN'S MONTH CELEBRATION THEME "**BABAE SA LAHAT NG SEKTOR, AANGAT ANG BUKAS SA BAGONG PILIPINAS**" REINFORCES THE GOAL OF EMPOWERING WOMEN ACROSS ALL SECTORS.

ADVANCING LGBTQIA+ RIGHTS AND INCLUSION

LOCAL ANTI-DISCRIMINATION ORDINANCES (ADOS): IN THE ABSENCE OF NATIONAL LEGISLATION, MANY PROVINCES AND CITIES HAVE ENACTED THEIR OWN ADOS (E.G., QUEZON CITY, Aklan, Albay), PROVIDING LOCAL PROTECTIONS AGAINST DISCRIMINATION BASED ON SOGIESC.

"RIGHT TO CARE" INITIATIVES: PROPOSED NATIONAL LEGISLATION AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT INITIATIVES (LIKE QUEZON CITY'S "**RIGHT TO CARE**" CARD, LAUNCHED JUNE 2023) AIM TO GRANT LGBTQIA+ COUPLES THE RIGHT TO MAKE CRITICAL HEALTH DECISIONS FOR THEIR PARTNERS

GOVERNMENT COMMITMENTS: EXECUTIVE ORDER NO. 51 (2023) CREATED A SPECIAL COMMITTEE ON LGBTQIA+ AFFAIRS TO ADDRESS DISCRIMINATION AND FACILITATE COMMUNITY PARTICIPATION IN POLICY FORMULATION. THE BJMP ALSO ESTABLISHED A SPECIAL DETENTION FACILITY FOR LGBTQ+ PDLS (**PERSONS DEPRIVED OF LIBERTY**) IN MANILA CITY JAIL (FEBRUARY 2025).

WORKPLACE INCLUSION: THE PHILIPPINE FINANCIAL & INTER-INDUSTRY PRIDE (PFIP) RELEASED ITS 2024 IMPACT REPORT, SHOWCASING EFFORTS TO PROMOTE LGBTQ+ INCLUSION IN THE WORKPLACE THROUGH GUIDES, FORUMS, AND A GROWING NETWORK OF 101 MEMBER COMPANIES.

ADVANCING LGBTQIA+ RIGHTS AND INCLUSION

ADVOCACY AND AWARENESS: LARGE-SCALE PRIDE EVENTS (E.G., JUNE 2025 **PRIDE PH** FESTIVAL WITH OVER **250,000 ATTENDEES**) DEMONSTRATE GROWING PUBLIC SUPPORT AND SERVE AS POWERFUL PLATFORMS FOR ADVOCATING FOR THE SOGIESC EQUALITY BILL AND BROADER LGBTQIA+ RIGHTS. EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS LIKE CMU (**CENTRAL MINDANAO UNIVERSITY**) AND UPOU (**UNIVERSITY OF THE PHILIPPINES OPEN UNIVERSITY**) ARE CONDUCTING SOGIE BILL ORIENTATIONS AND PRIDE MONTH CELEBRATIONS (MAY-JUNE 2025).

CSO INITIATIVES: ORGANIZATIONS LIKE SAVE THE CHILDREN PHILIPPINES' "PROJECT PRIDE" ARE WORKING TO PROTECT AND INCLUDE CHILDREN WITH DIVERSE SOGIESC IN POLICIES AND PROGRAMS.

FOSTERING ALLYSHIP AND INCLUSIVITY

1

IMPORTANCE

CRUCIAL FOR CHALLENGING PATRIARCHAL NORMS, PREVENTING GBV, AND FOSTERING SHARED RESPONSIBILITY FOR GENDER EQUALITY AND LGBTQIA+ INCLUSION. ALLIES, BOTH MEN AND WOMEN, ARE ESSENTIAL IN CREATING SAFE AND AFFIRMING ENVIRONMENTS FOR ALL.

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PHILIPPINE INITIATIVES

CRUCIAL FOR CHALLENGING PATRIARCHAL NORMS, PREVENTING GBV, AND FOSTERING SHARED RESPONSIBILITY FOR GENDER EQUALITY AND LGBTQIA+ INCLUSION. ALLIES, BOTH MEN AND WOMEN, ARE ESSENTIAL IN CREATING SAFE AND AFFIRMING ENVIRONMENTS FOR ALL.

FUTURE LEADERS & SUSTAINING PROGRESS

1

INVESTING IN YOUTH

ONGOING EFFORTS TO ENSURE GENDER PARITY IN EDUCATION, THOUGH THE RECENT DIP IN PRIMARY SCHOOL ENROLLMENT FOR GIRLS NEEDS ATTENTION. PROGRAMS PROMOTING GENDER-INCLUSIVE EDUCATION AND LEADERSHIP FOR YOUNG WOMEN AND LGBTQIA+ YOUTH.

2

LONG-TERM VISION

THE PHILIPPINE PLAN FOR GENDER-RESPONSIVE DEVELOPMENT (PPGD) 1995-2025 AND THE GEWE PLAN 2019-2025 PROVIDE A LONG-TERM FRAMEWORK. THE PCW'S 50TH ANNIVERSARY IN 2025 HIGHLIGHTS SUSTAINED COMMITMENT TO GENDER EQUALITY.

RECOMMENDATIONS & CALL TO ACTION

SOLUTIONS



1

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

STRENGTHEN ENFORCEMENT AND IMPLEMENTATION OF CURRENT GENDER EQUALITY LEGISLATION (E.G., MAGNA CARTA OF WOMEN, SAFE SPACES ACT).

STOP THE DECREASING SEX RATIO AT BIRTH AND SCHOOL ENROLLMENT AMONG GIRLS THROUGH FOCUSED INTERVENTIONS.

FORMULATE PARTICULAR POLICIES TO IMPROVE THE REPRESENTATION OF WOMEN IN POLITICAL AND CORPORATE LEADERSHIP.

STRENGTHEN GENDER-SENSITIVE LANGUAGE AND PROCEDURES IN LAND PUBLIC LAWS AND AGRARIAN REFORM.

IMPERATIVELY PASS THE SOGIESC EQUALITY BILL AS SOON AS POSSIBLE TO GRANT EXTENSIVE NATIONAL LEGAL PROTECTION FROM DISCRIMINATION.

SEEK LEGAL GENDER RECOGNITION FOR TRANSGENDER AND GENDER NON-CONFORMING PEOPLE.

UNIVERSALIZE AND IMPLEMENT "RIGHT TO CARE" PROGRAMS ACROSS THE COUNTRY TO SAFEGUARD LGBTQIA+ COUPLES' RIGHTS.

2

COMMUNITY ACTIONS

ADVOCATE FOR BYSTANDER INTERVENTION AND REPORTING OF GBV AGAINST BOTH GENDERS AND SOGIESC.

ASSIST LOCAL WOMEN'S ORGANIZATIONS AND INITIATIVES, AND LGBTQIA+ ADVOCACY GROUPS AND SAFE SPACES.

COUNTER GENDER STEREOTYPES AND BIASES IN DAY-TO-DAY LIFE AND MEDIA, INCLUDING THOSE AGAINST LGBTQIA+ INDIVIDUALS.

ENGAGE MEN AND BOYS AS ACTIVE AGENTS OF GENDER EQUALITY AND LGBTQIA+ INCLUSION ADVOCACY.

DEVELOP INCLUSIVE SETTINGS IN SCHOOLS, WORKPLACES, AND COMMUNITIES THAT AFFIRM DIVERSE SOGIESC.

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SOLUTIONS



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